VANTAGE FREIGHT & LOGISTICS PVT. LTD.

Standard Operating Procedures — Warehouse, Dispatch & Fleet Safety | SOP-WD-2026-v2

1 PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This document defines the mandatory operating procedures for warehouse loading, vehicle dispatch, cold-chain handling, fire safety, vehicle maintenance, and incident reporting across all Vantage Freight & Logistics depots. These procedures apply to all warehouse staff, dispatch supervisors, and drivers operating under a Vantage Freight contract, whether directly employed or engaged through a registered transport vendor.

Shift supervisors are required to confirm procedure completion in the daily dispatch log before any vehicle is cleared for departure. Non-compliance with any section of this SOP must be recorded as a deviation and escalated to the depot manager within the same shift.

2 WAREHOUSE LOADING PROTOCOL

- Verify the shipment manifest against the physical count before loading begins.
- Fragile or hazardous cargo must be flagged in the WMS and loaded last for easy offload access.
- Maximum vehicle load must not exceed 90% of the rated axle capacity.
- The loading supervisor signs off on the Loading Compliance Sheet (Form VFL-LC-02) before the vehicle gate pass is issued.
- Pallets exceeding 1.8 metres in stacked height require additional strapping per the depot's current safety circular.

3 DRIVER DISPATCH CHECKLIST

3.1 Pre-Trip Verification

- Confirm the driver's licence validity and current medical fitness certificate.
- Complete the vehicle pre-trip inspection: brakes, tyres, lights, and GPS tracker signal.
- Log the route plan and estimated arrival time in the dispatch system before departure.

3.2 Departure Readiness

- Verify the presence of an emergency contact card and a stocked first-aid kit.
- Confirm the fuel card balance is sufficient for the round trip plus a 15% buffer.
- Obtain the loading supervisor's signed gate pass before the vehicle exits the depot.

4 COLD CHAIN HANDLING (PERISHABLE CARGO)

- Reefer unit temperature must be logged at loading, mid-route, and delivery checkpoints.
- Any deviation beyond +/- 2 degrees Celsius from the set point must be reported to the depot duty manager immediately.
- Pre-cooling of the cargo bay is mandatory at least 30 minutes before loading begins.
- Perishable shipments exceeding 6 hours in transit require a mandatory mid-route inspection stop, logged in the dispatch system.

5 WAREHOUSE SAFETY AND FIRE COMPLIANCE

- Fire extinguishers are inspected monthly; inspection tags must be updated and logged.
- Aisle clearance of at least 1.2 metres must be maintained at all times in every storage zone.
- No open flame or smoking is permitted within 15 metres of any loading dock.
- An emergency evacuation drill is conducted quarterly per depot, with attendance logged and retained for two years.

6 VEHICLE MAINTENANCE GUIDELINES

- Preventive maintenance is scheduled every 10,000 km or 90 days, whichever occurs earlier.
- Brake pad wear is inspected at every service interval and replaced below 20% remaining thickness.
- Tyre rotation is performed every second service to ensure even wear across all axles.
- Any vehicle flagged 'Under Review' in the incident log is grounded pending inspection and may not be dispatched until cleared by the fleet maintenance team.

7 INCIDENT REPORTING REQUIREMENT

Any accident, cargo damage, delay exceeding four hours, or safety violation must be logged within two hours of occurrence. Incident IDs follow the format INC followed by an eight-digit sequence number, assigned automatically by the incident logging system at the time of filing. Severity-HIGH incidents require depot manager sign-off within 24 hours, and severity-CRITICAL incidents must be escalated to the Regional Operations Head immediately by phone, followed by a written report within four hours.

7.1 Escalation Matrix

Severity	Initial Response Time	Escalation Path
LOW	Within same shift	Shift supervisor logs and closes
MEDIUM	Within 4 hours	Depot manager reviews and signs off
HIGH	Within 24 hours	Depot manager sign-off + regional notification
CRITICAL	Immediate (phone) + 4-hour written report	Regional Operations Head + Compliance Officer

8 DOCUMENTATION AND RECORD RETENTION

All loading compliance sheets, pre-trip inspection checklists, cold-chain temperature logs, and incident reports must be retained at the depot level for a minimum of three years from the date of creation, and made available to the Compliance Office or any regulatory authority upon request. Digital copies uploaded to the central WMS satisfy this requirement in place of physical retention, provided the upload is completed within 48 hours of the record being created.

8.1 Retention Schedule

Record Type	Retention Period	Storage Location
Loading Compliance Sheets (Form VFL-LC-02)	3 years	Depot + central WMS
Pre-trip inspection checklists	2 years	Depot + central WMS

Record Type	Retention Period	Storage Location
Cold-chain temperature logs	3 years	Central WMS
Incident reports (all severities)	5 years	Compliance Office archive
Fire safety inspection tags	2 years	Depot

9 TRAINING AND CERTIFICATION REQUIREMENTS

All warehouse staff and drivers must complete depot-specific induction training before being assigned independent duties, and must complete an annual refresher covering the sections of this SOP relevant to their role. Training completion is logged against each employee's ID in the HR training module, and depot managers are responsible for ensuring no staff member operates past their refresher due date.

- New warehouse staff: mandatory 2-day induction covering Sections 2, 4, and 5 before independent floor duties begin.
- New drivers: mandatory 1-day induction covering Sections 3 and 4, plus a supervised trial run of at least one full route.
- Hazmat-certified drivers: additional specialised training renewed every 12 months, independent of the general annual refresher.
- Depot managers and shift supervisors: annual refresher additionally covers Section 7 escalation procedures and this document's most recent revisions in full.

10 VENDOR-OPERATED VEHICLE REQUIREMENTS

Where a shipment is dispatched using a vehicle operated by a third-party transport vendor under contract with Vantage Freight & Logistics, the depot dispatching the shipment remains responsible for verifying that the vendor's vehicle and driver meet all applicable sections of this SOP before departure. A vendor's own internal procedures do not substitute for this verification.

- Confirm the vendor vehicle carries a valid AIS-140 GPS tracking device before dispatch, per Circular 16/2025.
- Confirm the vendor driver's licence and medical fitness certificate independently, even if the vendor has already verified these internally.
- Log the vendor's registration number and driver ID in the dispatch system against the shipment record for traceability.
- Any deviation observed in a vendor vehicle's condition or documentation must be reported to the Compliance Office within 24 hours, in addition to the standard incident log entry if the deviation resulted in a delay or safety concern.

11 REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
SOP-WD-2024-v1	Jan 2024	Initial consolidated release
SOP-WD-2025-v1	Aug 2025	Added cold-chain inspection stop requirement
SOP-WD-2026-v2	Feb 2026	Added vendor-operated vehicle requirements; revised escalation matrix

12 DEPOT CONTACT DIRECTORY

The following contacts should be used for escalations and compliance queries specific to each depot. This directory is updated whenever a depot management change occurs and should be cross-checked against the most recent circular before use.

Depot	Depot Manager Contact	Zone
Bhiwandi Central Hub	+91-98200-10001	Western

Depot	Depot Manager Contact	Zone
Pune Warehouse	+91-98200-10002	Western
Delhi NCR Hub	+91-98200-10003	Northern
Chennai Depot	+91-98200-10004	Southern
Kolkata Depot	+91-98200-10005	Eastern
Hyderabad Depot	+91-98200-10006	Southern

This document is maintained by the Operations Excellence team. Questions regarding interpretation of any section should be directed to opsexcellence@vantagefreight.example.in.

This SOP is reviewed annually by the Operations Excellence team, or immediately following any CRITICAL-severity incident. The current version supersedes SOP-WD-2024-v1 in full.